

Malabar on the Mind

A poet's first novel brings alive the voyage of Vasco da Gama



FOR PEPPER AND CHRIST

by KEKI N. DARUWALLA
Penguin
Price: Rs 399
Pages: 354

| By Gillian Wright |

Keki N. Daruwalla is one of India's best known and best loved English poets. With *For Pepper and Christ*, he has written a historical novel centred on the voyages of Vasco da Gama. Like the best historical novelists, Daruwalla does not mess with facts and keeps very close to the accounts we have of the explorations of da Gama and his predecessors as they began a new phase of Western

expansion—linking the Malabar coast with Europe by a sea route around the coast of Africa.

Although da Gama was an experienced explorer, he did not have the confidence to strike out from the African coast across to Malabar without a local pilot. Portuguese accounts give this pilot a name, but he has never

been properly identified. Daruwalla makes this pilot the main character in his novel. He calls him Taufiq, the son of an Egyptian seaman. With his father, Taufiq has lived for years in Gujarat and sailed as far as Calicut and Cochin. Through him and other characters from the lands being "discovered" by Portugal, Daruwalla shows how the Portuguese appeared to those in the sophisticated trading nations that had discovered each other many centuries before da Gama was born.

Taufiq studies in the glorious city of Cairo ruled by Mamluk Sultans and policed by a repressive keeper of public morals. Much of Egypt's wealth came from the trade between India and Europe. Arab and Egyptian dhows carried spices from Malabar and Malacca to the Red Sea ports, as well as to the Gulf ports of Hormuz and Basra. In a long-standing arrange-

ment, approved by the Pope, the merchants of Venice held the trading rights to do business with the "infidel" and buy these goods, leaving no scope for Portuguese traders. By this time, the Ottoman Turks controlled the East-West trade across the Bosphorus, and so Portugal planned to circumnavigate all these vested interests and take direct control of the spice trade itself.

Daruwalla's Portuguese have another area of exploration too. In Africa, apart from gold and slaves, they are searching for a mythical Christian saint-king, Prester John, who they believed ruled a vast area south of Egypt and could help them control the Muslims of North

Africa. For da Gama, the world was so completely divided between Muslims and Christians that, when he finally arrived at the court of the Hindu ruler of Calicut, he was convinced that since he was not a Muslim, he must be a Christian. For de Gama, Hindu temples were churches dedicated

to the Virgin Mary, and Brahmins Christian priests. Taufiq laughs heartily at his employers for this, and for their incessant mispronunciation of Arab and Indian words. However, he doesn't have a lot of opportunity for humour. Even though he does find time to fall in love, he is caught up in the dramatic events of his time.

Intrigue, suspicion and aggression abound in this novel. Its natural climax comes with da Gama's second voyage to the East—one not of exploration but retribution, an early example of the use of disproportionate force. By incorporating so many strands of what was a complex historical process, Daruwalla succeeds in presenting a panorama of the world at the end of the 15th century. *For Pepper and Christ* is indeed an unusual and exceptional first novel.



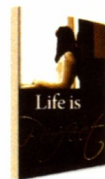
BUSHRA HASAN



STREET FOOD OF INDIA

by SEPHI BERGERSON
Roli Books
Price: Rs 695
Pages: 192

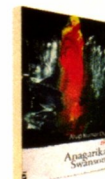
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Anwsha
Price: Rs 300
Pages: 434

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